FRANCE · NORTHWESTERN FRANCE

Normandy, Brittany & Loire

4 Day Road Journey

DESTINATION	DURATION	IDEAL FOR
France, Northwestern France	4 days	2–5 people

YOUR JOURNEY

Expedition Route

France · Northwestern France · 4 days

DAY 1
Paris · Rouen · Étretat · Honfleur

DAY 2
Honfleur · Omaha Beach · Mont-Saint-Michel

DAY 3
Mont-Saint-Michel · Saint-Malo · Dinan

DAY 4
Dinan · Chenonceau · Chambord

JOURNEY HIGHLIGHTS

- Étretat cliffs at first light — the arches and needles of the Alabaster Coast
- Omaha Beach and the Normandy American Cemetery
- Château de Chenonceau spanning the River Cher
- Honfleur harbour: the most painted fishing port in France
- Mont-Saint-Michel at high tide, when the causeway vanishes
- Château de Chambord — the hunting lodge that became a palace

DAY 1

Normandy — Rouen, Étretat & Honfleur

Begin in Rouen — the old town, the Gothic cathedral, the square where Joan of Arc was burned. Drive the Alabaster Coast to Étretat: the chalk arches and needle are best in early morning when the light hits them obliquely. Lunch in the village. Drive along the coast to Honfleur for the night: the Vieux Bassin harbour, the timber-framed houses, the restaurants that don't need to try.

- Rouen Cathedral — the subject of Monet's most famous series, a masterwork of Gothic stone
- Étretat — the chalk sea arches and needle spire of the Alabaster Coast
- Honfleur Vieux Bassin — the 17th-century harbour that launched a school of painting

INSIDER TIP

Étretat's chalk arches are best photographed in the first hour after sunrise, when the light strikes obliquely and the beach is empty. The cliff walk west to the Porte d'Aval arch is accessible to all and has the best vantage points. Honfleur's restaurants are significantly better than their tourist-facing menus suggest — ask for the formule.

DAY 2

D-Day Beaches — Omaha, Pointe du Hoc & Mont-Saint-Michel

Drive west along the coast. Omaha Beach in the morning: the sand, the bluffs, the cemetery where 9,387 Americans are buried. Pointe du Hoc — the cliffs the Rangers scaled on June 6th, 1944. Drive south in the afternoon toward Mont-Saint-Michel, timed for arrival near high tide when the mount becomes an island. Dinner in Saint-Malo.

- Omaha Beach — the most contested of the D-Day landing beaches
- Normandy American Cemetery — 9,387 graves on the bluff above the sea
- Pointe du Hoc — the German gun battery the Rangers climbed under fire
- Mont-Saint-Michel — the tidal island abbey that has drawn pilgrims since 709 AD

INSIDER TIP

Mont-Saint-Michel tides are extreme — the causeway floods predictably but the timing changes daily. Check the official timetable before planning your arrival. The abbey interior requires a ticket and closes at 6pm; the village streets are free and atmospheric at any hour.

DAY 3

Brittany — Saint-Malo & Dinan

Morning inside the walls of Saint-Malo — the granite ramparts, the old corsair city rebuilt stone by stone after 1944. Drive south to Dinan: a perfectly preserved medieval town above the River Rance that almost no one visits. Lunch in the old town. Drive south toward the Loire Valley for the night.

- Saint-Malo ramparts — the intra-muros city rebuilt identically after wartime destruction
- Dinan old town — 15th-century half-timbered streets above the Rance valley
- Cap Fréhel — the pink granite headland between the two towns

INSIDER TIP

Saint-Malo's rampart walk is best before 9am when it is empty. Dinan is almost entirely unvisited by international tourists despite being one of the most intact medieval town centres in France — give it two hours rather than a passing stop.

DAY 4

Loire Valley — Chenonceau & Chambord

Two châteaux, chosen because they represent opposite ends of the same ambition. Chenonceau in the morning: the feminine château, built over the river by women, quieter and more human than its neighbours. Chambord after lunch: Francis I's hunting lodge that became an obsession, an unfinished palace with 440 rooms and a double-helix staircase that may or may not have been designed by Leonardo.

- Château de Chenonceau — the Renaissance château bridging the River Cher
- Château de Chambord — 440 rooms, 365 fireplaces, and a double-helix grand staircase
- Loire vineyards — Vouvray and Sancerre country, worth a stop

INSIDER TIP

Chenonceau opens at 9am and the first hour is quieter than any other time. The château is approached through a tree-lined avenue of plane trees — magnificent in any season. Chambord's roof terraces are its most overlooked feature: the viewing platforms above the double-helix staircase offer views of the Loire countryside for miles.

HIDDENATLAS

Ready to make this trip yours?

This guide gives you the structure and route.
Our planners can build the personalised version around your dates, travel style and pace.

- Refined route planning and pacing
- Carefully selected areas to stay
- Logistics guidance for a smooth journey
- Insider tips from on-the-ground research

START PLANNING YOUR TRIP
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